

Chapter 4: The Customer Who Came Back

Three days later, Austin Blackwood returned.

Not once.

Not twice.

Three times.

By the end of the week, everyone at the Golden Dragon Restaurant had noticed.

Especially Bao.

"He's here again."

Jenny didn't look up from her order pad.

"So?"

"So?" Bao nearly dropped a tray. "The man practically declared war on you a week ago."

"He likes the food."

Bao snorted.

"He likes something."

Jenny shot him a warning look.

"Finish that sentence and I'll make you clean the kitchen."

Bao wisely walked away.

The lunch rush had just begun when the front door opened.

Jenny didn't need to look.

She somehow knew.

A strange feeling settled in her chest.

Sure enough, Austin walked in.

His dark coat was perfectly tailored.

His shoes probably cost more than her monthly rent.

And somehow, he still managed to look annoyed.

At everything.

The weather.

The customers.

Life itself.

The hostess approached him.

But before she could speak, Austin said,

"Table by the window."

The same table.

Every time.

The hostess nodded and led him over.

Jenny tried to ignore him.

She really did.

Unfortunately, Austin seemed determined to make that impossible.

A few minutes later, Madam Chen appeared beside her.

"Table seven."

Jenny looked up.

"No."

Madam Chen raised an eyebrow.

"What do you mean no?"

"You have other waiters."

"And he requested you."

Jenny froze.

"What?"

Madam Chen's lips twitched.

"He requested your section."

Across the room, Austin was reviewing the menu.

As if he hadn't just caused her problems.

Jenny stared at him.

"Why?"

Madam Chen shrugged.

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"You can ask him."

Jenny grabbed a menu.

"This is ridiculous."

"Probably."

"He's ridiculous."

"Also true."

Madam Chen walked away before Jenny could complain further.

Taking a deep breath, Jenny approached the table.

Austin glanced up.

For a split second, something flashed in his eyes.

Relief.

It vanished so quickly she almost imagined it.

"Good afternoon."

Jenny forced a professional smile.

"What can I get for you today?"

Austin closed the menu.

"The Imperial Seafood Noodles."

Jenny stared.

"The same thing?"

"Yes."

"The dish with the hair?"

A few nearby customers looked over.

Austin sighed.

"It was one hair."

Jenny blinked.

"Oh? I thought it was a national emergency."

His jaw tightened.

Jenny enjoyed that far more than she should have.

"Anything else?" she asked.

"Tea."

"Anything else?"

"No."

She wrote it down.

Then paused.

"Just to confirm."

Austin narrowed his eyes.

"What now?"

"You don't want a side order of complaints?"

For a moment, he simply stared.

Then something unexpected happened.

He laughed.

A real laugh.

Not the brief chuckle from before.

An actual laugh.

Jenny nearly dropped her pen.

Austin noticed.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You look shocked."

"I'm not shocked."

"You are."

She was.

Because laughing made him look human.

And she wasn't sure she liked that.

It was easier to dislike him when he acted like a jerk.

The kitchen prepared his order quickly.

When Jenny returned, she carefully placed the bowl in front of him.

Then she pulled a hair from her own head.

Austin's eyes widened.

Jenny dropped it dramatically onto the table.

"There."

"What are you doing?"

"Preparing for later."

A nearby customer laughed.

Austin rubbed his forehead.

"You're impossible."

"Yet you keep coming back."

The words slipped out before she could stop them.

For a moment, silence stretched between them.

Austin met her gaze.

Neither looked away.

Finally, he said quietly,

"Maybe the food is worth it."

Jenny wasn't convinced.

Not even a little.

The rest of the lunch service passed surprisingly peacefully.

Austin ate.

Jenny worked.

And somehow, he kept finding reasons to call her over.

More tea.

Extra napkins.

Questions about menu items he had ordered dozens of times before.

By the fourth request, Jenny had enough.

"What?"

Austin looked up.

"What?"

"You keep calling me over."

"You're my server."

"You asked where the restroom was."

"I needed directions."

"You were sitting ten feet from the sign."

A hint of amusement appeared in his eyes.

Jenny pointed at him.

"You're doing it on purpose."

"Doing what?"

"Being annoying."

Austin took another sip of tea.

"Perhaps."

Jenny opened her mouth.

Then closed it.

Because unfortunately, she had no response to that.

Across the room, Bao was watching.

Grinning.

The traitor.

The lunch rush finally ended.

Customers gradually left.

Austin remained seated.

Reviewing documents.

Checking numbers.

Working.

Jenny couldn't help noticing how focused he became.

How different he looked when he wasn't arguing.

She immediately hated herself for noticing.

A few minutes later, Austin gathered his papers.

As he stood, a single sheet slipped from the stack.

Neither of them noticed.

Not yet.

Austin headed for the door.

Then disappeared outside.

Jenny began clearing tables.

When she reached his, she spotted the paper.

A financial report.

Probably important.

Very important.

She picked it up.

At the bottom was a figure so large she nearly dropped the page.

The amount was more money than she would earn in twenty years.

Maybe thirty.

Her eyes widened.

"That's insane."

The restaurant door suddenly opened again.

Austin stepped inside.

His gaze immediately found the paper in her hands.

And for the first time since she had met him...

He looked genuinely worried.

"Jenny," he said sharply.

"Give me that."

She looked from the paper to his face.

Then back again.

Whatever was on those pages...

It mattered.

A lot.

And now she was curious.

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